

Understanding the opportunities in the open source world

Open source is the way to go for any budding entrepreneur, feels Nagar. "Apart from reducing your costs, the flexibility proposition and its ability to create a wholesome platform is eye catching for any budding entrepreneur," says Nagar. While e-commerce and CMS are segments worth considering, sectors like financial institutions, the public sector and retail hold huge opportunities for entrepreneurs into open source technology. However, here is a word of caution! "Take time to understand open source for what it is. If you are working on only open source, don't promote the free argument alone. Look at what open source is, as a whole. Always focus on the flexibility, choice and innovation argument of open source to sell and win over customers. Lastly, be a part of the open source ecosystem and contribute back to the community," advises Nagar.

InfoAxon win new business over the years. "We realised very early on that we would be taking a great risk if we focused on customising open source rather than on what the technology can do. Thus, we focused on selling a 'complete solution', which were our 'platforms' to the customer. Alongside, we used our existing assignments like the APLAWS project to reach out to new customers like the European arm of UNDP, Indian Air Force etc. In a nutshell, our platforming focus soon fell in sync with our business model and value proposition," says Nagar.

Dahiya adds: "After the APLAWS experience, we realised the opportunity in the public sector and the international development arena, and decided to focus on these sectors. We also kept preaching to the already convinced, like those in the banking and finance sector, who were on the constant lookout for newer technologies and were already bowled over by the open source idea."

Platforming – the trump card for InfoAxon

'Solution platforms', also called platforming, wherein various open source tools/platforms were integrated into one solution, was the USP and key differentiator for InfoAxon. "Our experience has taught us that most organisations, which have realised the value of open source or are in the process of realising it, don't want to implement select open source tools as a quick fix solution, or if they do, they realise quickly that they are on the wrong track. They want to integrate a whole lot of open source technologies and create a unique platform for their needs within their own domain. We provide them such platforms around knowledge management (KM), business intelligence (BI) and content management systems (CMS) with a vision to provide so much more in the future and to do so in diverse domains," says Nagar.

Since these platforms could be extended to develop solutions for different domains/ markets, they hold the promise of reducing the overall time to market for customers. One of the firm's noteworthy platforms is "AxonShare",

which is a 'collaborative content management platform' that can be used to create content-centric collaboration solutions that help organisations address the challenge of knowledge sharing. It combines collaboration and social capabilities with back-end enterprise content management capabilities to provide end-to-end content and collaboration functionality. "FusionKM" is another workflow enabled social network-based knowledge management platform that provides infrastructure and a robust design by which new services could be built into the solution. InfoAxon is also involved in developing large scale knowledge management platforms with integrated business intelligence for the international development sector.

Is 'platforming' a viable business model?

With platforming currently contributing nearly 70 per cent to InfoAxon's revenue stream, there is no doubt about its profitability. "The business model around platforming is a unique one. As open source began maturing, the cost proposition took a back seat and the flexibility and innovation edge it provides came to the forefront. In such a situation, the customer wanted someone who could cement many open source tools together for them to avail the wholesome benefits of open source. This is where we came in with our 'platforming packages', which was the first revenue stream for us. Thereafter, we worked on enhancements for the platforms, adding satellite modules/applications. This triggered an additional revenue stream for us in the long run. We also provided maintenance and support of the whole platform, which soon became a significant revenue offshoot from our platforming solutions. Thus, our platforming approach resulted in long lasting relationships with customers, with many continuing with us for nearly five to six years and more," explains Nagar.

Today, InfoAxon has several customers of their platforming solutions who have been with them for over five years. Home Connections, which is a service provider of Choice Based Letting (CBL) services (in the social housing domain) to local authority partners and housing associations in the UK, is one of them. Starting with providing a CBL platform powered by open source technologies, InfoAxon soon found yet another opportunity to add modules like housing registers, implement an interface with digital TV where people could bid for affordable housing using their interactive TV interfaces, etc. Another instance of platforming leading to new opportunities for InfoAxon was with the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), for whom the firm had developed a KMS platform. The relationship continued to grow, when UNDP approached InfoAxon to add features like allowing the other initiatives to search content within UNDP using this platform. So was the case of the South African government whose association with InfoAxon began with a social networking platform for aid management and thereafter, it chose InfoAxon again to